

Haddock (*Melanogrammus aeglefinus*) in divisions 7.b–k (southern Celtic Seas and English Channel)

ICES advice on fishing opportunities

ICES advises that when the maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach and precautionary considerations are applied, there should be zero catch in 2027.

ICES notes the existence of a precautionary management plan, developed and adopted by one of the relevant management authorities for this stock.

Non-fisheries conservation considerations

Conservation aspects and associated management measures may exist at a national or regional level but were not reviewed by ICES.

Stock development over time

Fishing pressure on the stock is above F_{MSY} but below F_{PA} , and spawning-stock size is below MSY $B_{trigger}$ B_{PA} , and B_{lim} .

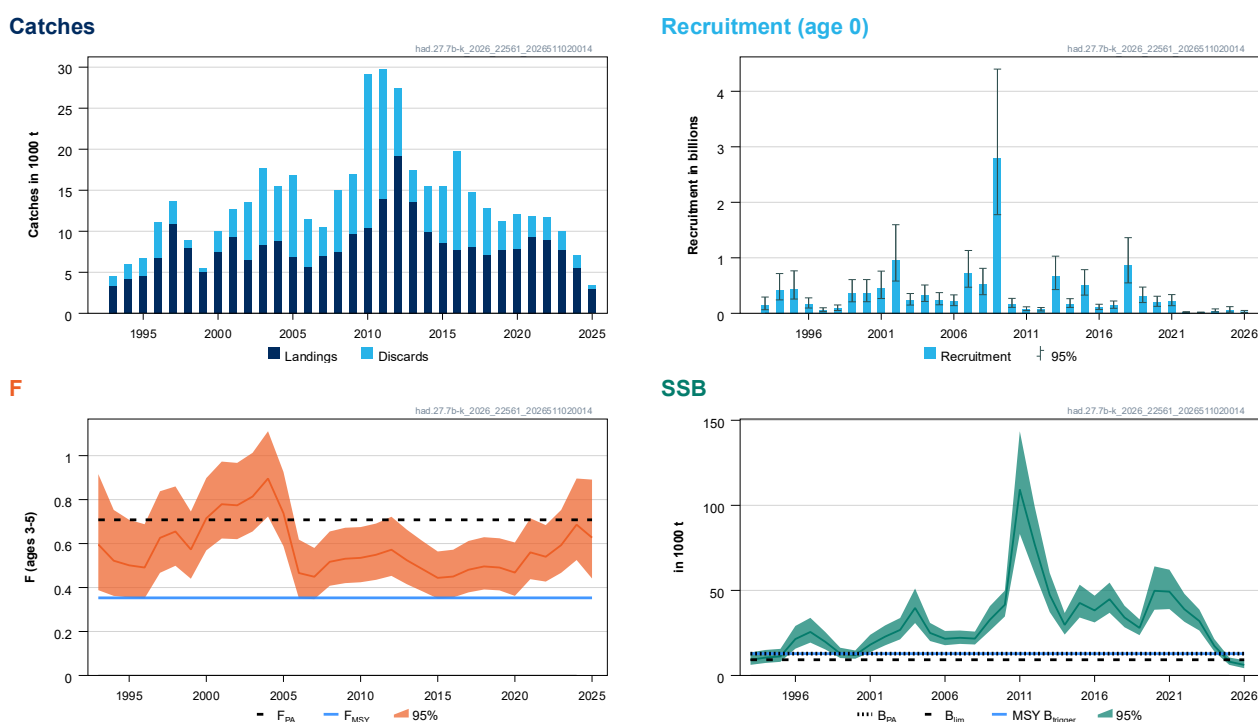


Figure 1 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Summary of the stock assessment. The assumed recruitment value for 2026 is shaded in a lighter colour.

Catch scenarios

Table 1 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Values in the forecast and for the interim year.

Variable	Value	Notes
$F_{ages\ 3-5}$ (2026)	0.64	Average exploitation pattern (2023–2025), scaled to average $F_{ages\ 3-5}$ in 2023–2025
Spawning-stock biomass (SSB; 2027)	5306	Short-term forecast; in tonnes
$R_{age\ 0}$ (2026, 2027)	32271	Resampled recruitments from the years 2022–2025 (median shown); in thousands
Total catch (2026)	2696	Short-term forecast; in tonnes
Projected landings (2026)	2018	Short-term forecast; assuming average landings ratio by age 2023–2025; in tonnes
Projected discards (2026)	678	Short-term forecast; Assuming average discard ratio by age 2023–2025; in tonnes

Table 2 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Annual catch scenarios. Weights are in tonnes.

Basis	Total catch (2027)	Projected landings (2027)	Projected discards (2027)	F_{total} (2027)	$F_{projected}$ landings (2027)	$F_{projected}$ discards (2027)	Spawning -stock biomass (SSB; 2028)	% SSB change*	% TAC change [^]	% probability SSB < B_{lim} in 2028 [#]
ICES advice basis										
Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach: $F = 0$	0	0	0	0	0	0	6299	19	-100	92
Other scenarios										
$F_{MSY} \times SSB_{2027}/MSY B_{trigger}$	582	426	156	0.146	0.117	0.029	5712	8	-68	96
$F_{MSY lower} \times SSB_{2027}/MSY B_{trigger}$	374	275	99	0.091	0.074	0.017	5925	12	-79	95
EU MAP ^{^^} : F_{MSY}	1282	927	355	0.353	0.28	0.069	5032	-5	-30	98
EU MAP ^{^^} : $F_{MSY lower}$	851	620	231	0.221	0.178	0.043	5446	3	-53	97
F_{PA}	2236	1577	659	0.708	0.57	0.139	4118	-22	23	100
$SSB_{2028} = B_{lim}^{^^^}$										
$SSB_{2028} = B_{PA} = MSY B_{trigger}^{^^^}$										
$SSB_{2028} = SSB_{2027}$	998	725	273	0.26	0.21	0.052	5306	0	-45	97
$F = F_{2026}$	2063	1460	603	0.64	0.51	0.124	4279	-19	13	99

* SSB 2028 relative to SSB 2027.

[^] Catch advice in 2027 relative to the 2026 TAC (1824 tonnes).

^{^^} EU multiannual plan (MAP) for the Western Waters (EU, 2019).

^{^^^} These options were left blank because they cannot be achieved in 2028, even with zero catch in 2027.

[#] The probability of SSB being below B_{lim} in 2028. This probability relates to the short-term probability of $SSB < B_{lim}$ and is not comparable to the long-term probability of $SSB < B_{lim}$; fishing mortalities less than F_{PA} have been shown to have less than 5% probability of the stock being below B_{lim} in the long term when tested through simulations when estimating fishing mortality reference points

The advice for 2027 is the same as for 2026: zero catch. The zero-catch advice is mainly due to a reduction in stock size following recent low recruitments and a low recruitment assumption for 2026 and 2027. ICES provides zero-catch advice for this stock because the spawning-stock biomass (SSB) is forecast to remain below B_{lim} in 2028 under all catch scenarios.

Basis of the advice

Table 3 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. The basis of the advice.

Advice basis	Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach
Management plan	ICES is aware of the multiannual management plan (MAP) that has been adopted by the EU for this stock (EU, 2019) and that ICES considers to be precautionary. There is no agreed shared management plan between the EU and UK for this stock, and ICES provides advice according to ICES MSY approach and precautionary considerations. Catch scenarios consistent with the MAP F_{MSY} ranges are provided.

Quality of the assessment

Estimates of SSB are consistently revised downwards and F upwards when assessments are updated with a new year of data. This pattern is considered to be within an acceptable range (ICES, 2020b) and does not affect the zero-catch advice.

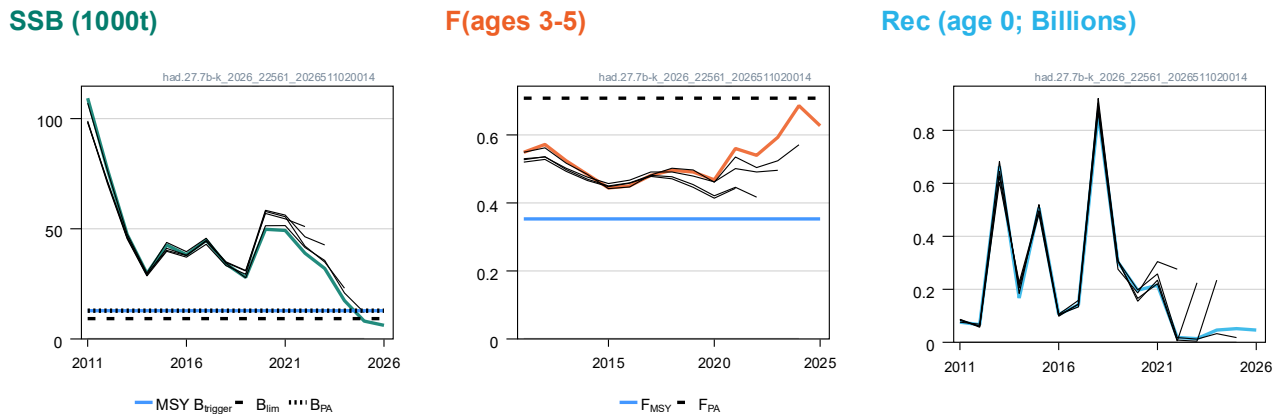


Figure 2 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Historical assessment results (final-year recruitment assumption and spawning-stock biomass [SSB] estimate included for each line).

Issues relevant for the advice

Recruitment since 2022 has been extremely low, which has led to a large reduction in stock size. The SSB in 2027 is below B_{lim} , and the SSB in 2028 is forecast to decline further. The main driver for the recent low recruitment is unknown but may persist; therefore, the recruitment assumption in the forecast was based on the last four years (2022–2025) only because they are considered to be representative of the current low recruitment level.

The assessment and the advice are for divisions 7.b–k, including the rectangles 33E2 and 33E3, as haddock in these rectangles are considered to be part of the haddock.27.7.b–k stock (western English Channel and southern Celtic Seas). Landings data used in the haddock.27.7.a assessment exclude those reported from rectangles 33E2 and 33E3 (Table 8). Data from these rectangles are incorporated into the advice for haddock.27.7.b–k. In 2025, haddock landings in 33E2 and 33E3 (82t) were 1.6 times the landings from the rest of Division 7.a and constituted 3% of the landings from the haddock.27.7.b–k stock. The spatial limitation of the advice should be considered when setting total allowable catches (TACs) for the two management areas that span the haddock.27.7.a and 27.7.b–k stocks.

ICES notes that the assessment area does not correspond to the TAC area. However, landings outside the assessment area are generally less than 1% of the total landings in the TAC area.

Mixed-fisheries considerations

Haddock in divisions 7.b–k is caught as part of a mixed fishery (ICES, 2026b).

Reference points

Table 4 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Reference points, values, and their technical basis.

Framework	Reference point	Value	Technical basis	Source
Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) approach	MSY $B_{trigger}$	12822	B_{PA} ; in tonnes	ICES (2020a)
	F_{MSY}	0.353	Based on simulation using a segmented regression stock–recruitment relationship (EqSim)	ICES (2020a)
Precautionary approach	B_{lim}	9227	Lowest observed spawning-stock biomass (SSB); in tonnes	ICES (2020a)
	B_{PA}	12822	B_{lim} combined with the assessment error; $B_{lim} \times \exp(1.645 \times \sigma)$; $\sigma = 0.20$ (default setting); in tonnes	ICES (2020a)
	F_{PA}	0.708	F_{P05} ; the F that leads to $SSB \geq B_{lim}$ with 95% probability	ICES (2020a)
Management Plan*	MAP MSY $B_{trigger}$	12822	MSY B_{PA} ; in tonnes	EU (2019), ICES (2020a)
	MAP B_{lim}	9227	Lowest observed SSB; in tonnes	EU (2019), ICES (2020a)
	MAP F_{MSY}	0.353	F_{MSY}	EU (2019), ICES (2020a)
	MAP range $F_{MSY lower}$	0.221	Consistent with ranges resulting in no more than 5% reduction in long-term yield compared with MSY	EU (2019), ICES (2020a)
	MAP range $F_{MSY upper}$	0.521	Consistent with ranges resulting in no more than 5% reduction in long-term yield compared with MSY	EU (2019), ICES (2020a)

* EU multiannual plan (MAP) for the Western Waters and adjacent waters (EU, 2019).

Basis of the assessment

Table 5 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Basis of the assessment and advice.

ICES stock data category	1 (ICES, 2025)
Assessment type	Age-based analytical model SAM used in the assessment and the forecast (ICES, 2026a)
Input data	Commercial catches (age composition of landings and discards); vector autoregressive spatio-temporal (VAST) (Thorson <i>et al.</i> 2016) standardized survey index (combined IGFS-WIBTS-Q4 [G7212] and EVHOE-WIBTS-Q4 [G9527]); maturity data (surveys and observer data; constant for all years); age-dependent natural mortality (time invariant; Lorenzen, 1996). Stock weights were based on Q1 catch weights, smoothed with a three-year running average.
Discards and bycatch	Included in the assessment for the full time-series. Full observer-based estimates from 2005, partial observer-based estimates from 1993 to 2004.
Indicators	None
Other information	This stock was benchmarked in 2020 (ICES, 2020a)
Working groups	Working Group for the Celtic Seas Ecoregion (WGCSE)

History of the advice, catch, and management

Table 6 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. ICES advice, the agreed total allowable catch (TAC), official landings and ICES estimates of landings and discards. All weights are in tonnes.

Year	ICES advice	Catch corresponding to advice	Landings corresponding to advice	Agreed TAC	Official landings	ICES landings ^{##}	ICES discards ^{^^^}	ICES catch
1987	Not dealt with				3000 ^{^^}	2600 ^{^^}	n/a	2600 ^{^^}
1988	Not dealt with				4000 ^{^^}	3600 ^{^^}	n/a	3600 ^{^^}
1989	Not dealt with				4200 ^{^^}	3200 ^{^^}	n/a	3200 ^{^^}
1990	Not dealt with				2900 ^{^^}	2000 ^{^^}	n/a	2000 ^{^^}
1991	Not dealt with				2900 ^{^^}	2300 ^{^^}	n/a	2300 ^{^^}
1992	Not dealt with				2900 ^{^^}	2700 ^{^^}	n/a	2700 ^{^^}
1993	Not dealt with				3400 ^{^^}	3348	1208	4556
1994	Not dealt with				4076	4131	1886	6017
1995	Not dealt with			6000 [*]	4468	4470	2218	6688
1996	Not dealt with			7000 ^{**}	6653	6756	4309	11065
1997	Not dealt with			14000	10270	10827	2883	13710
1998	Not dealt with			20000	7360	7928	934	8862
1999	Not dealt with			22000 ^{***}	5247	4970	586	5556
2000	No expansion of catches			16600 ^{***}	6656	7499	2503	10002
2001	No expansion of catches			12000 ^{***}	9702	9278	3418	12696
2002	No expansion of catches		8000	9300 ^{***}	7089	6488	7073	13561
2003	No expansion of catches		7200	8185 ^{***}	8241	8292	9456	17748
2004	No increase in F			9600 ^{***}	8453	8777	6750	15527
2005	No increase in effort			11520 ^{***}	6867	6839	9953	16792
2006	No increase in effort			11520 ^{***}	5621	5592	5899	11491
2007	No increase in effort			11520 ^{***}	6628	6961	3552	10513
2008	Same advice as last year			11579 ^{***}	6234	7392	7660	15052
2009	Same advice as last year			11579 [^]	9308	9664	7322	16986
2010	Same advice as last year			11579 [^]	9999	10429	18701	29130
2011	See scenarios			13316 [^]	13709	13957	15807	29764
2012	No increase in catch and technical measures to reduce discard rates			16645 [^]	18221	19196	8285	27481
2013	Maximum sustainable yield (MSY) transition		< 9500	14148 [^]	13098	13538	3962	17501
2014	MSY transition	< 5281	< 3602	9479 [^]	9372	9846	5619	15464
2015	MSY approach	< 10434	< 5605	8342 [^]	8229	8608	6941	15549
2016	MSY approach	≤ 8590	≤ 6078	7258 [^]	7024	7648	12065	19713
2017	MSY approach	≤ 12444	≤ 7751	7751 [^]	7374	8099	6691	14789
2018	MSY approach	≤ 8358	≤ 5911	6910 [^]	6595	7046	5798	12844
2019	MSY approach	≤ 6317		8329 [^]	6861	7656	3603	11259
2020	Management plan	16671 (range 11418-23262)		10859 [^]	7308	7859	4260	12119
2021	Management plan	18382 (range 12128-25454)		15000 [^]	8480	9267	2519	11786
2022	MSY approach	≤ 15946		15000 [^]	8045	8900	2805	11706
2023	MSY approach	≤ 11901		11901 [^]	6917	7729	2259	9988
2024	MSY approach	≤ 8252		8252 [^]	4966 [#]	5484	1624	7108
2025	MSY approach	≤ 4644		6353 [^]	2855 [#]	2923	455	3378
2026	MSY approach and precautionary considerations	0		1824 [^]				
2027	MSY approach and precautionary considerations	0						

* Applies to subareas 7–10; ** Increased in-year to 14 000 tonnes; *** Includes separate Division 7.a allocation.

[^] Applies to 7b–k, 8, 9 and 10; EU waters of Fishery Committee for the Eastern Central Atlantic (CECAF) 34.1.1.

^{^^} Values presented to the nearest 100.

^{^^^} Discard estimates are available from 2005; prior to 2005, discard estimates are based on limited sampling.

[#] Preliminary; ^{##} Including landings from rectangles 33E2 and 33E3 since 2003.

History of the catch and landings

Table 7 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Catch distribution by fleet in 2025, as estimated by ICES.*

Catch	Landings					Discards				
3378 tonnes	Otter trawls 54%	Beam trawls 5%	Seines 33%	Gillnets 6%	Other gears 2%	Otter trawls 32%	Beam trawls 53%	Seines 13%	Gillnets 1%	Other gears 1%
	2923 tonnes					455 tonnes				

* The figures in the table are rounded. Calculations were done with unrounded inputs, and computed values may not match exactly when calculated using the rounded figures in the table.

Table 8 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. History of official landings by country and ICES estimates of landings and discards. Weights are in tonnes.

Year	Official landings						ICES estimates			
	Belgium	France	Ireland	UK	Others	Total	Landings from rectangles 33E2 and 33E3**	Landings	Discards ***	Catch
1993	51	1839	1262	256	0	3408		3348	1208	4556
1994	123	2788	908	240	17	4076		4131	1886	6017
1995	189	2964	966	266	83	4468		4470	2218	6688
1996	133	4527	1468	439	86	6653		6756	4309	11065
1997	246	6581	2789	569	85	10270		10827	2883	13710
1998	142	3674	2788	444	312	7360		7928	934	8862
1999	51	2725	2034	278	159	5247		4970	586	5556
2000	90	3088	3066	289	123	6656		7499	2503	10002
2001	165	4842	3608	422	665	9702		9278	3418	12696
2002	132	4348	2188	315	106	7089		6488	7073	13561
2003	118	5781	1867	393	82	8241	64	8292	9456	17748
2004	136	6130	1715	313	159	8453	53	8777	6750	15527
2005	167	4174	2037	292	197	6867	35	6839	9953	16792
2006	99	3191	1874	274	183	5621	26	5592	5899	11491
2007	119	4143	1931	385	50	6628	222	6961	3552	10513
2008	109	3638	1800	566	121	6234	194	7392	7660	15052
2009	131	5430	2983	716	48	9308	285	9664	7322	16986
2010	170	6240	2609	852	128	9999	267	10429	18701	29130
2011	211	8389	3323	1657	129	13709	374	13957	15807	29764
2012	232	11793	4129	1901	166	18221	473	19196	8285	27481
2013	174	8747	2699	1455	23	13098	410	13538	3962	17501
2014	99	6375	2092	785	21	9372	444	9846	5619	15464
2015	118	5679	1657	769	6	8229	322	8608	6941	15549
2016	88	4487	1730	692	27	7024	468	7648	12065	19713
2017	110	4885	1677	690	12	7374	715	8099	6691	14789
2018	89	4470	1444	583 ^c	9	6595 ^c	532	7046	5798	12844
2019	90	4526	1559	516 ^c	170	6861 ^c	764	7656	3603	11259
2020	107	3808	2628	543	222	7308	559	7859	4260	12119
2021	157	4250	3408	517 ^c	149	8480 ^c	827	9267	2519	11786
2022	193	3787	3132	588	234	8045	865	8900	2805	11706
2023	118	2855	2989	668	287	6917	831	7729	2259	9988
2024*	81	1880	2118	615	272	4966	503	5484	1624	7108
2025*	61	799	1425	383	188	2855	82	2923	455	3378

* Preliminary landings.

** Landings in the southern part of Division 7.a (rectangles 33E2 and 33E3) are included in the assessment and are considered part of the stock.

*** Prior to 2005, discard estimates are based on limited sampling.

^c Incomplete/missing as a result of part of the data being unavailable under data confidentiality clauses.

Summary of the assessment

Table 9 Haddock in divisions 7.b–k. Assessment summary. “High” and “low” refer to 95% confidence intervals. Weights are in tonnes and recruitment in thousands. ICES estimates of landings and discards which are used as assessment inputs.

Year	Recruitment (age 0)			SSB			Landings	Discards **	Fishing mortality (ages 3–5)		
	Low	Value	High	Low	Value	High			Low	Value	High
1993	64642	137649	293113	6229	9181	13532	3348	1208	0.39	0.60	0.92
1994	241784	416170	716331	7345	10494	14993	4131	1886	0.36	0.52	0.75
1995	257103	443522	765108	8004	11190	15644	4470	2218	0.36	0.50	0.71
1996	95227	162826	278410	15739	21403	29106	6756	4309	0.35	0.49	0.69
1997	34084	58367	99952	19314	25577	33871	10827	2883	0.47	0.63	0.84
1998	50857	87493	150522	15282	19756	25540	7928	934	0.50	0.66	0.86
1999	207178	354707	607292	10222	12905	16292	4970	586	0.44	0.57	0.75
2000	209018	356457	607899	9815	12007	14690	7499	2503	0.57	0.72	0.90
2001	266507	450124	760248	13682	18078	23888	9278	3418	0.62	0.78	0.97
2002	581221	963230	1596315	17701	22825	29432	6488	7073	0.62	0.77	0.97
2003	148815	230371	356624	21220	26773	33780	8292	9456	0.66	0.81	1.01
2004	213858	330321	510208	30807	39675	51094	8777	6750	0.72	0.90	1.11
2005	153469	239229	372913	20248	25010	30892	6839	9953	0.59	0.74	0.93
2006	138325	214367	332212	17777	21561	26150	5592	5899	0.35	0.47	0.62
2007	470109	729448	1131851	18549	22133	26410	6961	3552	0.35	0.45	0.58
2008	335432	521365	810360	18186	21658	25792	7392	7660	0.41	0.52	0.66
2009	1777274	2796347	4399746	26283	32721	40737	9664	7322	0.42	0.53	0.67
2010	106728	169454	269045	34653	41577	49885	10429	18701	0.42	0.54	0.68
2011	49268	75971	117145	83169	109266	143551	13957	15807	0.44	0.55	0.69
2012	42568	66606	104219	59789	76957	99054	19196	8285	0.45	0.57	0.72
2013	427834	663672	1029512	37247	47372	60249	13538	3962	0.42	0.52	0.66
2014	105691	166963	263758	24043	29716	36726	9846	5619	0.38	0.48	0.61
2015	328131	507997	786455	34057	42627	53353	8608	6941	0.35	0.44	0.56
2016	67557	104983	163142	31168	38231	46894	7648	12065	0.36	0.45	0.57
2017	90296	141587	222014	36821	44826	54570	8099	6691	0.38	0.48	0.61
2018	548049	864273	1362957	28323	34066	40974	7046	5798	0.39	0.50	0.63
2019	193739	302591	472600	23687	27944	32966	7656	3603	0.39	0.49	0.62
2020	125554	196509	307563	38631	49769	64118	7859	4260	0.36	0.47	0.61
2021	137515	215391	337368	39015	49250	62169	9267	2519	0.44	0.56	0.72
2022	11372	18406	29791	31546	38921	48020	8900	2805	0.43	0.54	0.68
2023	8531	13757	22184	26397	31982	38748	7729	2259	0.47	0.59	0.75
2024	26701	46137	79718	14112	17398	21448	5484	1624	0.53	0.69	0.90
2025	22140	51583	120180	6228	8099	10532	2923	455	0.44	0.63	0.89
2026	16756*	32271*	54755*	4250	6190	9029					

* Resampled recruitments from the years 2022–2025 (median shown).

** Discard estimates are available from 2005; prior to 2005, discard estimates are based on limited sampling.

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